ALESSANDRO PIZZIGOLOTTO

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ACADEMIC APPOINTMENTS

Postdoctoral Researcher September 2023 – present
Department of Economics, University of Copenhagen

EDUCATION

Ph.D. in Economics 2018–2023
Norwegian School of Economics (NHH)

Doctoral Thesis	*Essays on Empirical Political Economy and Household Behaviour*
Examiners	Vincent Somville (NHH, chair), Gloria Gennaro (UCL), Matia Vannoni (KCL)
Supervisors	Katrine V. Løken and Jósef Sigurdsson
Research Visits	Stockholm University, Department of Economics: October 2021 – July 2022
	Instituto Tecnológico Autónomo de México (ITAM): January 2022

M.Sc. in Economics and Finance 2014–2017
Università degli Studi di Padova *with distinction*

Curriculum	Banking and Finance
Exchange Student	University of Helsinki, M.Soc.Sc. in Economics

B.Sc. in Economics and Management 2011–2014
Università degli Studi di Padova

High School Diploma in Software Engineering 2011
Istituto Tecnico Industriale Statale "F. Severi" *Final grade: 100/100*

TEACHING AND RESEARCH INTERESTS

Primary Political Economy, Applied Microeconomics
Secondary Cultural Economics, Economic History, Household Finance, Labour Economics

REFERENCES

Jeanet Sinding Bentzen, Professor
Department of Economics
University of Copenhagen
Øster Farimagsgade 5, building 26, office 26.2.26,
1353 København K, Denmark
jeanet.bentzen@econ.ku.dk (Advisor and PI)

Katrine V. Løken, Professor
Department of Economics
Norwegian School of Economics (NHH)
Helleveien 30, 5045 Bergen, Norway
katrine.loken@nhh.no (Supervisor)

Jósef Sigurdsson, Associate Professor
Department of Economics
Stockholm University
Universitetsvägen 10A, 114 18 Stockholm, Sweden
josef.sigurdsson@su.se (Supervisor)

Jaakko Meriläinen, Associate Professor
Department of Economics
Stockholm School of Economics
Sveavägen 65, 11383 Stockholm, Sweden
jaakko.merilainen@hhs.se (Co-Author)

PUBLICATIONS

Divine Policy with Jeanet Sinding Bentzen and Lena Lindbjerg Sperling

The Impact of Religion in Government

American Economic Journal: Applied Economics 18(1), January 2026, 195–247

Press Coverage: AEA Research Highlights Article, VoxEU, EurekAlert!, Berlingske

Can policies shape personal values and beliefs? To examine, we exploit the staggered introduction of faith-based initiatives across US states. Our difference-in-differences analysis reveals that the initiatives strengthened religiosity and conservative-religious social views, such as attitudes against homosexuals. The evidence points to causal effects; we find no systematic differences prior to implementation, the results are robust to restricting comparison to contiguous counties and to conducting triple-differences estimation exploiting treatment heterogeneity. A key explanation, in line with standard models of religion and supported by data on nonprofit organizations, is that the initiatives facilitated the establishment of faith-based organizations.

Essays on Empirical Political Economy and Household Behaviour

Ph.D. Dissertation, Norwegian School of Economics (NHH), August 2023

SELECTED WORK IN PROGRESS

Credit Shocks and Populism with Nicolò Fraccaroli

This paper shows that credit shocks are key drivers of populist sentiment. Exploiting spatial variation in exposure to an exogenous lending cut by a large German bank in 2007–08, we find that exposure to the credit shock leads to a persistent increase in populist political preferences. To explore the shift in demand for populism activated by the shock, we measure the degree of populist rhetoric and the salience of bank-related topics to each party over time using a machine learning technique on the corpus of parliamentary speeches in Germany. A county-level analysis suggests that the underlying mechanism lies in the perceived decay of the local economy across voters that stems from the credit shock. A machine learning decomposition of the individual causal effects indicates that labour market history is the most important factor shaping the response in populist preferences.

Volcanic Protests with Jaakko Meriläinen, Matti Mitrunen, Arash Nekoei and Jósef Sigurdsson

Among the causes of the French Revolution, a "folk hypothesis" holds that the 1783 eruption of Laki, in Iceland, contributed to unrest in the revolutionary years. We present the first empirical evidence on this hypothesis and on how the eruption influenced the nature of the Revolution. The sinking air of an anticyclone brought the haze of the eruption down to the ground unevenly in France. Comparing the places more and less exposed, before and after 1783, we show that the more exposed places faced a larger rise in the price of grain, following the harsh winter after the eruption. Dear grain turned into protests. The same places had more subsistence riots after the eruption and again in the early years of the Revolution, above all in the towns, where people bought their grain. As grain riots spread, the Third Estate wrote its grievances in the *cahiers de doléances* and elected its deputies to the *Estates-General*. The more exposed places moved away from its liberal programme, putting food before representation. Fewer of their deputies were men of the law, who led the Third Estate. Their parishes asked less often for the vote by head, leaning toward the regulation of the trade in grain. However, the general *cahiers* of their districts, drawn up by local notables, were less likely to defend the *Ancien Régime*. As the eruption changed what the Revolution was about in the places it hit hardest, our results broadly suggest that natural disasters carry political consequences as well as economic ones, with implications for societal stability as extreme weather events become more frequent.

Learning from a Systemic Banking Crisis' Experience
The Long-Run Impact on Borrowing Behaviour with Michele Cantarella and Nicolò Fraccaroli

Does the experience of a banking crisis have an effect on households' portfolios? We investigate this question by focusing on households that migrated to Germany between 1950 and the 2007 financial crisis. Combining data on migrants from 123 different countries with data on systemic banking crises, we identify the impact of the crisis' experience through the variation in the timing of arrival. We compare households' portfolios of those with a household head that experienced a systemic banking crisis in her country of ancestry with those that did not. Focusing on loan portfolios, we find that households that witnessed at least one crisis earlier in their lives are less likely to hold consumer loans than those that never experienced a crisis. Moreover, we show that the probability of borrowing is lower for migrants who experienced multiple crises compared to those that experienced a single episode, suggesting a cumulative effect of banking shocks. We propose analogous evidence on real estate portfolios. Overall, our results suggest that the cost of financial crises is not limited to the short-term effects driven by losses in wealth and income, but includes a long-lasting effect due to households changing their behaviour.

Written in the Taxes with Jeanet Sinding Bentzen
Insights on the Role of Religion from Millions of Tax Statements

Religion is not just a private matter. Using full-count administrative data from IRS filings for nonprofit organizations covering tax years 2009 to 2023, we document its substantial role in public life. We estimate that 14.4 percent of the public charities that report a mission statement are religious, and that the religion code which the IRS assigns at registration misses about half of them. Through text analysis of their missions and names, we find three patterns. First, while explicitly religious domains – such as churches and faith-based congregations – are almost entirely religious, we also uncover a substantial religious footprint in areas typically perceived as secular, including international aid and pregnancy-related services. Religious pregnancy organizations, for instance, emphasize crisis support with faith-based language, whereas secular counterparts focus on reproductive healthcare and access. Second, religious philanthropy is directed primarily toward human beneficiaries. Whereas the topics in which religious organizations are most concentrated serve people, animal welfare and environmental topics are almost entirely secular, which suggests that religion shapes the direction of prosocial activity rather than simply its level. Third, mission statements reveal substantive value differences between religious and secular organizations. Although organization names can also carry explicit religious markers in some cases, these surface identifiers capture only part of the differences. Together, our findings provide a new perspective on how religion shapes the goals, language, and scope of nonprofit activity in the United States.

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

AØKA08087U Advanced Development Economics - Macro Aspects Guest Lecturer, Fall 2025
University of Copenhagen *MSc/PhD Level*

STR421 Competitive Strategy Teaching Assistant, Spring 2023
Norwegian School of Economics (NHH) *Master's Level*

ECN400 Macroeconomic Theory and Policy Teaching Assistant, Fall 2020
Norwegian School of Economics (NHH) *Master's Level*

ECN401 Applied Microeconomic Theory Teaching Assistant, Spring 2020
Norwegian School of Economics (NHH) *Master's Level*

ECN402 Econometrics Teaching Assistant, Fall 2019 – Fall 2022
Norwegian School of Economics (NHH) *Master's Level*

ECO433 Empirical Strategies for Causal Analysis Teaching Assistant, Spring 2019
Norwegian School of Economics (NHH) *Master's Level*

Risk, Uncertainty, and Political and Economic Behaviour 29 August 2023
Norwegian School of Economics (NHH) *Doctoral Trial Lecture*

Pedagogy Diploma for NHH Academic Staff Spring 2020
Norwegian School of Economics (NHH) *50 hours; participated and passed*

PRESENTATIONS AND CONFERENCES

2026 Helsinki GSE. SODAS Data Discussion (*joint with co-author*, University of Copenhagen). ASREC Europe 2026 Conference (University of Warwick Venice, Italy). University of Bergen. NBER Political Economy Program Meeting Fall 2026 (*attendee*, San Francisco, CA). NBER Economics of Religion Fall 2026 (*discussant*, San Francisco, CA).

2025 SPARRC Methodology Workshop 2025 (UCSD, CA). ASREC Europe 2025 Conference (University of Copenhagen).

2024 ASREC 2024 Conference (Chapman University (Orange County, CA), attending the annual workshop). 2nd Workshop in Economic History (Uppsala University, Sweden).

2023 Graduate Students in International Political Economy (GSIPE) Workshop (online). 5th Annual COMPTEXT Conference 2023 (University of Strathclyde, Glasgow). APSA Annual Meeting 2023 (Los Angeles, *canceled*).

2022 Instituto Tecnológico Autónomo de México (ITAM, Political Economy Group, Mexico City). University of Gothenburg. FAIR Midway Conference 2022 (Sommarøy, Norway, Poster Session). Norwegian School of Economics (Brownbag, CELE Coffee Meeting, Emerging Research Seminar).

2021 Scandinavian PhD Seminar (online). EPSA Virtual Conference 2021 (*joint with co-author*). XXXII Villa Mondragone International Economic Seminar (*joint with co-author*, Rome Tor Vergata/online). 2nd Monash-Warwick-Zurich Text-as-Data Conference (online). IFABS 2021 Oxford Conference (Saïd Business School, Oxford/online). Stockholm University (SU Labor Fika, Microwave Seminar). Joint Bank of England, the European Central Bank, King's College London and King's Business School Conference on new methods and applications for macroeconomic policy (*joint with co-author*, London/online).

2020 Norwegian School of Economics (Friday Lunch Seminar, Emerging Research Seminar). INET/Young Scholars Initiative: New Economic Questions (Political Economy of Europe Working Group (*joint with co-author*), Financial Stability Working Group, online).

RELEVANT SKILLS

Languages	Italian (native), English (fluent), Norwegian and Danish (survival skills)
Programming	C/C++, Java, PHP (pre-graduate), Python (intermediate), R (advanced), MATLAB (basic), TypeScript (basic)
Software	Stata (advanced), Excel, mySQL (intermediate), QGIS (intermediate), LaTeX

AWARDS, FELLOWSHIPS AND GRANTS

SPARRC Seed Research Grant (USD 150,000) 2025–2027
Templeton Foundation

Funding the Role of Religion in Crisis Response (ROREC) seed project (PI: Jeanet Sinding Bentzen), focused on using natural experiments and NLP techniques on U.S. non-profits to study the impact of religion and prosociality on disaster relief efforts. More than a half of the grant is allocated to my 2026–2027 stipend.

University Lecturer (50%) October 2022 – August 2023
Norwegian School of Economics (NHH), Department of Economics

Erasmus+ Scholarship for Training (at Barcelona GSE) Summer 2019
European Commission

Ph.D. Research Scholar (full stipend) 2018–2022
Norwegian School of Economics (NHH), Department of Economics
Contract allocation: 25% teaching and 75% research

Erasmus+ Scholarship 2015–2016
European Commission

PROFESSIONAL SERVICES

Meta-reviewer for the 2026 *European Association of Young Economists* (EAYE) Annual Meeting

REFEREEING ACTIVITIES

Swiss Journal of Economics and Statistics, *Journal of Economic Growth*

PAST APPOINTMENTS AND PROFESSIONAL EMPLOYMENT

Graduate Research Assistant July 2017 – July 2018
European Central Bank, Directorate General Research
Sonnemannstraße 20, 60314 Frankfurt am Main, Germany

Research Assistant related to the Household Finance and Consumption Network (HFCN) at the Directorate General Research of the European Central Bank. Main Research Project: "Monetary Policy and Household Inequality". *Principal Investigators*: Oreste Tristani, Jiří Slačálek.

Credit Analyst Assistant June 2014 – August 2014
Cassa Centrale Banca S.p.A. *Via Segantini, 5, 38122 Trento, Italy*

Web Developer, Software Developer and Webmaster November 2011 – March 2013
Bortolami Ricambi s.a.s. *Via Marco Polo, 35020 Albignasego, Italy*

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